Patel has suggested that some of the opposition to his design was "coloured by the fact that people dislike the government"


ANI

turned spokesman for the project with a quiet alacrity that was, at least initially, effective in distracting a potentially hostile public. Soft-spoken, urbane and cosmopolitan, the Berkeley-educated Patel was disarmingly quick to concede that the scheme deserved a more thorough process of public consultation and that some elements of his initial design (such as the demolition of the National Archives building) were mis-steps. However, it soon became apparent that his impeccable manners were just that and not a sign of a conciliation or compromise, much less self-doubt. In an interview with this magazine, Patel was voluble and unselfconscious in presenting his design as both transformative and somehow unobtrusive. He was democratising the imperial assemblage by "turning a fortress over to the people" and, it seemed, simultaneously channelling his colonial predecessor, doing "exactly what Lutyens would have done". All-owing that the scale of his new buildings was larger, he was confident that "when someone sees it from a distance, they'll say 'it's all the same'".

But rather than parallels with Edwin Lutyens, some of Patel's critics resorted, predictably to comparisons with the smooth-talking Albert Speer, architect of Adolf Hitler's unrealised fantasy of re-making Berlin as a monumental 'Germania'. Patel may have felt wounded by the comparison but given his history of working with Modi, he was clearly not unprepared for low blows, suggesting that some of the opposition to his design was "coloured by the fact that people dislike the government" and were using the project as "a football to hit the government

The Central Vista: A Picture in Numbers

₹20,000 CRORE
A gross rough estimate of expenditure of all the planned development/ redevelopment works. All projects are planned in a phased and sequential manner till 2026

15 ACRES
Plot size of proposed new prime minister's residence near South Block

₹229.75 CRORE
Fee being paid to Bimal Patel's HCP Design to plan the redevelopment of Lutyens' Delhi, including new Parliament building and the government offices

900 MPs
can be seated in the revamped triangular Parliament building, according to the HCP plan